

THE BITCOIN BEACON

SUNDAY, JULY 5, 2026

A daily read on where bitcoin is actually being used

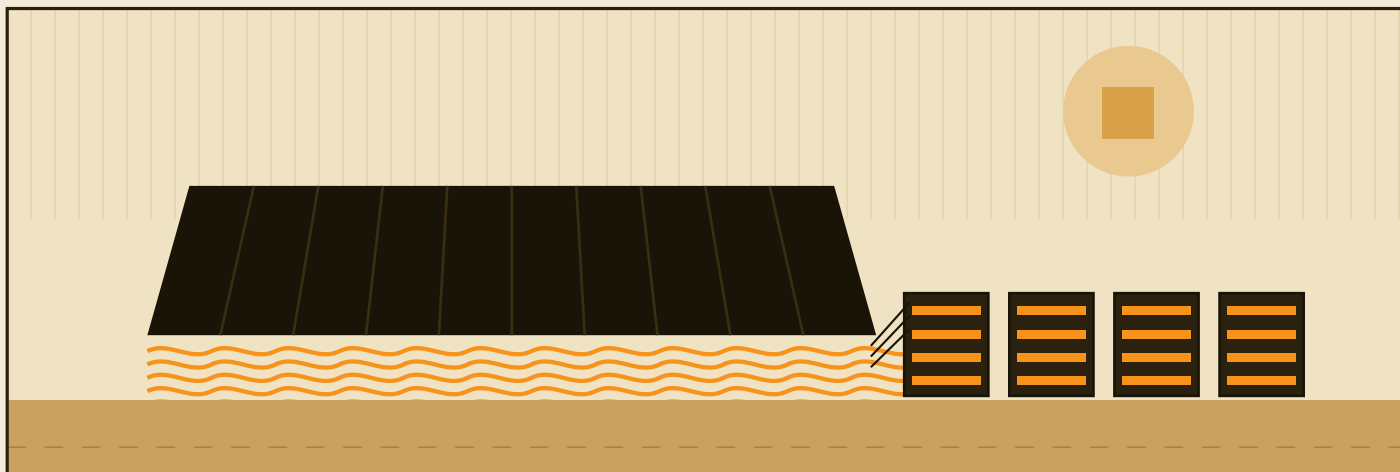
ADDIS ABABA · NAIROBI · TOKYO

HOLDERS ≥ \$100 ≈ 40M* addresses	BTC MAP MERCHANTS 25,000+* pins worldwide	NETWORK HASHRATE ≈ 945 EH/s all-time-high band	BTC / USD \$62,500 +1.3% / 24h
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THE LEAD

Ethiopia Wants to Mine Bitcoin as a State — Its Own Grid Is Fighting Back

Addis Ababa is turning surplus dam power into hashrate and asking for partners. The power utility that made it possible now wants the miners gone.



The Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam has become the country's mining engine — and its pressure point. — The Bitcoin Beacon

ADDIS ABABA — Ethiopia has spent two years quietly becoming one of the largest bitcoin-mining nations on earth, and now the government wants a formal cut of it. Ethiopian Investment Holdings, the sovereign vehicle sitting under the Prime Minister's office, has been courting partners with the capital, machines and expertise to run mining at national scale — the aim being to earn hashrate revenue *directly* for the state rather than leaving it to private operators alone.

The raw materials are already in place. Ethiopia is estimated at roughly 2.5% of global bitcoin hashrate — about 25 EH/s — putting it inside the world's top ten mining countries. The engine is the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam, which can push out more than 6,000 megawatts into a grid that cannot yet absorb even half of it. Miners are the buyer of last resort for power that would otherwise be stranded. Officials have floated the state owning 20–30% of the

mega-facilities now setting up on that surplus.

But the same utility that turned the dam into a magnet for miners is now leaning the other way. Ethiopian Electric Power scrapped its flat mining tariff late in 2025, lifting peak-hour costs by as much as 107%, paused new mining permits when capacity got tight, and has signalled it may phase private crypto miners off the grid entirely as domestic demand climbs. Foreign operators keep arriving anyway — Bitfumu picked up an 80MW site, Phoenix Group brought 30MW online — betting that four-cents-a-kilowatt-hour hydropower is worth the political weather.

The result is a contradiction the state must resolve in public: the Prime Minister's office wants an equity stake in mining while its own power company wants to ration the electricity that makes mining worth doing. Whoever wins that argument sets the template other energy-rich African states are already studying.

WHY IT MATTERS — This is the first serious test of bitcoin mining as *sovereign industrial policy* in the Global South: not a country holding coins, but a country turning its own idle electricity into hard-currency revenue. If Ethiopia squares the circle, hydropower-rich neighbours from the DRC to Kenya have a working blueprint to copy.

ON THE GROUND

KENYA · LIGHTNING

Nearly Every Kenyan Can Now Receive a Lightning Payment

NAIROBI — The quiet unlock in East Africa isn't a wallet — it's a bridge. The Tando app maps ordinary M-Pesa phone numbers into Lightning addresses, meaning roughly 40 million Kenyans can be on the receiving end of a bitcoin payment without downloading anything new. Money sent over Lightning settles in seconds and lands as spendable mobile-money credit.

The plumbing is visibly working at street level. In Kibera, Afribit Africa says it has onboarded more than 150 merchants, trained over 120 residents, and logged 2,000+ bitcoin transactions — many of them zero-fee hops from a Machankura wallet straight into M-Pesa. It was the headline conversation at the Bitcoin Nairobi conference this past month.

JAPAN · TREASURY

Metaplanet Crosses 43,000 BTC, Now the World's #3 Corporate Stack

TOKYO — Japan's Metaplanet added 2,823 BTC across the second quarter, its latest tranche worth about \$170 million, lifting the treasury to a round 43,000 BTC — roughly \$2.6 billion — and past every listed holder except Strategy and Twenty One Capital. The company's average cost sits near \$95,200 a coin against an aggregate \$4.09 billion outlay, which leaves the stack underwater at today's spot. Shares still popped 3.5% on the news, and its bitcoin "income" arm booked about \$11 million in operating revenue for the quarter — the market rewarding the accumulation flywheel even as the mark-to-market bleeds.

THE TAKE

OPINION

The World Quietly Gave Up on "Bitcoin as Cash" — and El Salvador Is the Proof

Nobody rang a bell, but the legal-tender era is over. After the 2025 amendment stripped out the mandate and the IMF deal made acceptance optional, no country on earth now holds bitcoin as full legal tender. The experiment that launched in San Salvador with a mandatory-acceptance law has, in practice, become something quieter and arguably more durable: a treasury strategy.

And El Salvador is leaning all the way into that second identity. The government keeps buying at roughly a coin a day — the reserve is now near 7,600 BTC — even though its estimated \$600 million in purchases sits above the reserve's current market value. On a spreadsheet, that's a loss. But a sovereign reserve isn't a trade; it's a multi-decade bet that a scarce, seizure-resistant asset is worth holding through the drawdowns. The country's own numbers hint the thesis has legs at street level too: crypto-linked remittances hit \$17.4 million in Q1, up nearly 50% year-on-year.

The lesson other governments are absorbing isn't "make merchants take bitcoin." It's "hold bitcoin like gold and let citizens use the rails if they want to." That's a smaller, less romantic idea than the 2021 vision — and a much easier one to actually execute.

— *The Bitcoin Beacon*, opinion

WHAT WE'RE WATCHING

■ **The SBI pool shutdown.** SBI Crypto's mining pool closes July 31, forcing ~21 EH/s — about 2.2% of the network — to find a new home. Watch where that hashrate re-pools.

■ **A downside call to test.** 10x Research's Markus Thielen argues the current bounce won't hold and BTC could probe \$46k–\$47k before a cycle low.

■ **West Africa's Lightning corridor.** WestToEast is wiring CFA-zone mobile money (Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire, Cameroon, Guinea) into Kenyan M-Pesa over Lightning.

■ **Who copies Ethiopia.** Will Kenya (geothermal) or the DRC (Congo River) move toward state-owned mining, or keep it fully private?

SOURCES

1. Ethiopia state-backed mining — [MEXC](#), [AInvest](#)

2. Ethiopia hashrate / GERD — [BitKE](#), [Coinfomania](#)
3. EEP tariff & phase-out — [The Reporter Ethiopia](#); miners — [Bitcoin.com](#), [DCD](#)
4. Kenya Tando / M-Pesa Lightning — [Crypto Briefing](#), [Coinspeaker](#); Kibera — [Tech-ish](#)
5. Metaplanet Q2 treasury — [CoinDesk](#), [Bitcoin.com](#), [The Block](#)
6. El Salvador reserve — [Bitcoin.com](#), [Anadolu](#); legal-tender — [Cryptonium](#)
7. SBI pool — [TechTimes](#); price/downside — [CoinDesk](#), [Coinpedia](#)
8. Metrics — hashrate [CoinWarz](#) / [minerstat](#); [BTC Map](#); holders $\geq$ \$100 [BM Pro](#)

*** Flagged as approximate:** the “Holders $\geq$ \$100” ($\approx$ 40M) and “BTC Map merchants” (25,000+, last published April 2026) figures could not be pulled live this run — verify on the linked Bitcoin Magazine Pro and BTC Map dashboards. Hashrate and price are current as of July 4–5. This PDF’s lead illustration is a house-style vector rendering of the digital edition’s AI hero art.

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Production note: this edition’s Charter / Memory / Art-Style / Template files were not reachable from this session’s workspace, so the issue was rebuilt from the standing brief and today’s reporting. No prior-edition memory was available to de-duplicate against.